

Introduction to Ethics

Philosophy 105

MWF 12:00 – 12:50, 311 Gregory Hall

Fall 2024

University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign

Instructor: Andrew L. Smith

Email: alsmit10 @ illinois.edu

Office: 202A Gregory Hall

Office Hours: M 1:00-2:30 and by appointment

Course Website: Canvas (canvas.illinois.edu)

Course Description

This course is an introduction to ethical theory. Our overall goal will be to try to understand various ways of responding to the question “how should I live?” We will begin the course by getting a sense of how to do philosophy in general before briefly engaging with some foundational issues in ethical theory. We will then move on to discussing three prominent approaches within ethical theory: utilitarianism, Kantianism, and Aristotelian virtue ethics. In addition, at various points in the course we will also consider ethical questions having to do with particular issues of contemporary concern, such as famine relief, pornography, and abortion. We’ll end by considering a certain sort of skepticism, articulated by Nietzsche, about the value of most of our various ethical attitudes – that is, those attitudes which we will have sought to understand in the earlier parts of the course.

Course Objectives

Upon completing this course, students should have developed a basic acquaintance with some prominent approaches to ethical issues and some classical philosophical texts. In addition, students should also have developed the ability to engage in philosophical discussions by developing the ability to read, assess, and respond to philosophical arguments.

Prerequisites

None.

Required Texts

John Stuart Mill, *Utilitarianism*, Hackett Publishing

Immanuel Kant, *Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals*, trans. Gregor, Cambridge

Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics*, trans. Ross, Oxford

Other readings listed in the schedule below will be made available on Canvas.

Grading

Three longer (4-5 page) papers (25pts each)

Eight short response papers (16pts total)

Participation (9pts)

Assignment and Grading Details

Longer papers: These are papers of about 4-5 full pages. Prompts will be provided, and there will be a choice of topics. The purpose of these longer papers is to give you the opportunity and the space to develop your thinking in a way not available on the short response papers. I don't read or comment on drafts, since I'm not able to do so for everyone, but I am happy to speak with you about your papers in office hours. The longer papers are submitted via Canvas, and they are graded on the standard A-F letter grade scale, about which I say more below. Late papers will be subject to a deduction of 1/3 letter grade

per day late unless some arrangement has been made because of a sufficiently serious issue (such as an illness). Papers cannot be rewritten or otherwise "made up."

Response papers: These will be assigned in weeks when you are not working on a longer paper. They will be a few paragraphs and will involve your developing a response to a question I will email to you. The goal is to help you get thinking about the material. Ten are assigned; you have to complete (at least) eight. These papers, like the longer papers, are submitted online through Canvas, and they are graded for completion in good faith: an assignment completed in good faith gets full credit, and otherwise no credit is awarded. Late response papers are not accepted, nor can they be rewritten or otherwise "made up."

Participation: Attendance is taken and is used, along with your level of involvement in the course, to determine a participation grade. (Coming to office hours and talking with me then also counts as participation.) Absences for sufficiently serious things, such as religious observances and illness, are excused.

Assignments and Plagiarism: At present, each assignment is to be completed outside of class. If I find that there is sufficiently widespread plagiarism, such as with the use of AI tools, such that the educational point of course assignments is undermined, I reserve the right to switch to in-class assignments, completed with pen and paper. Such a change would be announced, and I will work with students who have DRES testing accommodations to find an appropriate testing solution. (For more information, see the sections titled "Plagiarism and Academic Integrity" and "DRES Accommodations" below.)

Course grades: Grades for the course are calculated by adding the number of points received for the three papers, the response papers, and participation, and the total number of points determine the course grade according to the following scale:

≥93: A	83-86.9: B	73-76.9: C	63-66.9: D
90-92.9: A-	80-82.9: B-	70-72.9: C-	60-62.9: D-
87-89.9: B+	77-79.9: C+	67-69.9: D+	≤59.9: F

Plagiarism and Academic Integrity

Using anyone or anything's work, published or not, without proper citation and presenting it as your own work for this course constitutes plagiarism, and is a violation of the academic integrity policies of the university. (Note that this includes your own work for other courses, as well as text generated by LLM and AI tools, such as ChatGPT.) Submissions on Canvas are checked with Turnitin, a plagiarism detection tool, to ensure academic integrity standards are adhered to, and the FAIR (Faculty Academic Integrity Reporting) system is used to deal with academic integrity issues. The standard penalty for plagiarism is failure of the assignment, though a more severe penalty, such as failure of the course, may be imposed depending on the severity of the infraction.

You should speak with me in office hours or email me if you have *any* sort of question about how to avoid plagiarism, how to properly cite sources, and so on.

For more on academic integrity, such as what constitutes a violation thereof, possible sanctions, and so on, see Article I, Part 4 of the Student Code (<https://studentcode.illinois.edu/article1/part4/1-401/>) as well as the Students' Quick Reference Guide to Academic Integrity (<https://provost.illinois.edu/policies/policies/academic-integrity/students-quick-reference-guide-to-academic-integrity>).

DRES Accommodations

It is important that the environment of this course is well-suited to everyone. If you have a certain need I should attend to, please bring your Letter of Accommodation from Disability Resources and Educational Services to me during my office hours and we will work out a plan. For more information about DRES accommodations, see <http://disability.illinois.edu/academic-support/accommodations>.

Various Other Course Policies, Things to Know, etc.

Course decorum: We ought to treat ourselves and one another with respect; this includes speaking well and listening well. Be charitable and respectful to yourselves, to one another, and to me. Please limit the use of electronics in class to taking notes. When you email me, please use your university email address (so I can be sure I know who's emailing me in the first place).

Attendance and Participation: You should attend class regularly and participate, such as by actively listening to the lecture, taking notes, asking questions, and contributing to discussion. Participation also includes speaking with me in office hours about material in the course and philosophy more generally. If you're not able to attend class one day, an email is appreciated but you don't need to go above and beyond to prove to me that you are missing class for a good reason or anything like that. (What does that mean? It means your word is enough.) Finally, note that this is an in-person course, and as such, video call clients (such as Zoom) will not be used for any reason.

Handouts and slides: You should not expect to receive regular handouts, review sheets, PowerPoint slides, or anything like that in this course, so you should come to class and take notes. If you miss a day, get notes from a classmate.

On grades: Regarding what grades mean: "A" means "excellent." A paper which receives an A is an outstanding paper; this is a high bar, since a student who receives grades of A consistently, throughout a course of study in philosophy, could (potentially) go to graduate school in the discipline, and so grades of A are rare. "B" means "good." "C" means "fair." "D" means "poor." "F" means "fail."

Regarding communication about grades: Instructors aren't really supposed to email students about grades, due to FERPA (Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act) regulations, so you shouldn't email me with questions such as "What did I get on such-and-such assignment?" or "What is my grade in the course right now?" Questions about grades should instead be raised in office hours. (Besides, you can find your grades on our course website and figure out where you stand using the syllabus and a calculator.)

Doing philosophy in general: I do not expect you to be perfect, or to be a genius, or to immediately and effortlessly understand the course material. That would be unreasonable. But I do expect you to think for yourself and try to figure things out. Some tips that can help guide you in doing philosophy and help you try your best can be found at Jim Pryor's website:

<http://www.jimpryor.net/teaching/index.html>. In particular, you might find it helpful to look at his tips on reading philosophy, writing a philosophy paper, and his overview of some philosophical terms and methods.

In addition, I *highly* encourage you to come into office hours if you have questions about the material or problems understanding it. I cannot stress this enough. You do not need to have some super deep insight, question, or concern in order to come into office hours. That would also be unreasonable. Rather, you just need a question, concern, comment, or something like that which is honest. You can also come into office hours if you simply want to talk philosophy.

Readings: In my view, reading for a philosophy class is somewhat different from other classes. Typically the readings are shorter, but more difficult and demanding. To understand the readings, then, I suggest you read slowly (probably more slowly than you're used to) and engage the text actively as you read, such as by taking notes and asking questions in the margins, highlighting/underlining key concepts and arguments, and so on. Doing this will improve your reading ability. We will refer directly to the readings during class, so you should also bring the relevant text to class. I plan on uploading optional readings on Canvas from time to time: bear in mind that, by "optional," I mean *optional*, and there is no expectation that you even look at them. I want to provide them simply to give you other stuff to look at in case you're interested.

Writing: We will talk about how to write a philosophy paper in this course, though we will not go into great depth about things like basic English grammar, sentence structure, and so on. As such, if you are having trouble with these more technical aspects of writing, I encourage you to check out the resources offered by the Writers Workshop at <https://writersworkshop.illinois.edu/>.

AI/LLM tools: Don't use these. You do not improve your reading ability by asking ChatGPT to give you a summary of a reading, and you do not improve your writing ability by asking ChatGPT to write something for you. (And the idea that you cannot improve these abilities further is implausible. You did not peak in high school, and to think you did is to give up on yourself.)

Advising: I'm currently serving as undergraduate academic advisor for the Department of Philosophy, so get in touch with me if you would like to know more about studying philosophy here at the U of I. I'm happy to suggest future courses based on your interests, as well as to discuss the Philosophy major, the Computer Science + Philosophy major, and the Philosophy minor with you.

Schedule

Note: This schedule is subject to change; changes will be announced. This reading schedule is on the ambitious side, but I am not going to teach in a way that prioritizes sticking to the schedule over the development of student understanding. So, if we need to spend more time on the earlier readings than I have allotted in the schedule, that's cool – we'll cut some stuff. On days marked "TBD," we'll pick a reading that fits our interests from some of the suggestions I've included.

Week	Date	Reading	Assignments
1	Aug 26 Aug 28 Aug 30	Introduction to the Course (no reading) On Logic and Arguments (no reading) Logic and Arguments continued	
2	Sept 2 Sept 4 Sept 6	Labor Day – No class Aristotle, EN I.3; Plato, selections from <i>Euthyphro</i> and <i>Republic</i> Bentham, selections from <i>An Introduction to the Principles of Morals and Legislation</i> and <i>The Rationale of Reward</i>	Response paper 1
3	Sept 9 Sept 11 Sept 13	No class (In Germany for conference all week) - -	
4	Sept 16 Sept 18 Sept 20	Mill, <i>Utilitarianism</i> , ch. 1, 2 Mill, <i>Utilitarianism</i> , ch. 4 Mill, <i>Utilitarianism</i> , ch 4. cont'd	Response paper 2
5	Sept 23 Sept 25 Sept 27	On Writing a Philosophy Paper (no reading) Singer, "Famine, Affluence, and Morality" TBD: MacAskill, "Replaceability, Career Choice, and Making a Difference" or Bostrom, "Astronomical Waste: The Opportunity Cost of Delayed Technological Development" or McMahan, "The Meat Eaters"	Response paper 3
6	Sept 30 Oct 2 Oct 4	Williams, selections from "A Critique of Utilitarianism"; Nozick, "The Experience Machine" Kant, <i>Groundwork</i> I, all Kant, <i>Groundwork</i> I cont'd	Oct 6: Paper 1 due
7	Oct 7 Oct 9 Oct 11	Kant, <i>Groundwork</i> II, 4:406-424 Kant, <i>Groundwork</i> II 4:406-424 cont'd Kant, <i>Groundwork</i> II, 4:425-4:445	
8	Oct 14 Oct 16 Oct 18	Hill, "Pornography and Degradation" TBD: Hill, "Servility and Self-Respect" or Korsgaard, "Interacting with Animals: A Kantian Account" or Sussman, "Respect, Regret, and Reproductive Choice" or Velleman, "A Right to Self-Termination?" Wood, <i>Kant's Ethical Thought</i> (selections)	Response paper 5

9	Oct 21 Oct 23 Oct 25	Williams, “The Human Prejudice” Aristotle, <i>Nicomachean Ethics</i> I Aristotle, <i>Nicomachean Ethics</i> I cont’d	Response paper 6
10	Oct 28 Oct 30 Nov 1	Aristotle, <i>Nicomachean Ethics</i> II Aristotle, <i>Nicomachean Ethics</i> III.6-12, IV Aristotle, <i>Nicomachean Ethics</i> VI	
11	Nov 4 Nov 6 Nov 8	TBD: Driver, “The Virtues of Ignorance” or Galston, “Toughness as a Political Virtue” or Snow, “Is Hope a Moral Virtue?” TBD: Burnyeat, “Anger and Revenge” or Kerr, “To Envy an Algorithm” Doris, <i>Lack of Character</i> (selections)	Nov 10: Paper 2 due
12	Nov 11 Nov 13 Nov 15	Thomson, “A Defense of Abortion” Thomson cont’d Marquis, “An Argument that Abortion is Wrong”	Response paper 7
13	Nov 18 Nov 20 Nov 22	Thucydides, <i>History of the Peloponnesian War</i> 5.85-116; Geuss, “Thucydides, Nietzsche, and Williams” Nietzsche, selections from <i>Twilight of the Idols</i> Nietzsche, selections from <i>Beyond Good and Evil</i> ; Williams, “Nietzsche’s Minimalist Moral Psychology”	Response paper 8
14	Nov 25 Nov 27 Nov 29	Fall Break Fall Break Fall Break	
15	Dec 2 Dec 4 Dec 6	Nietzsche, <i>On the Genealogy of Morality</i> I Nietzsche, <i>On the Genealogy of Morality</i> I cont’d Nietzsche, <i>On the Genealogy of Morality</i> II	Response paper 9
16	Dec 9 Dec 11	Nietzsche, <i>On the Genealogy of Morality</i> II cont’d Catch-up day	Response paper 10 Paper 3 due: TBA